

Chapter 132_1 - Self-Control

Her voice was gentle and warm, heartbeat mixing with the rustling of leaves, bringing peace of mind. Ning Fuyi reached out to encircle her waist, quietly listening to her heartbeat.

Beat by beat, clear and strong.

"Chu Qingqiu, I want you to kiss me," Ning Fuyi suddenly said.

Chu Qingqiu's face flushed red. She lowered her head to look at the woman pulling away from her embrace, revealing crimson lips. After hesitating for a moment, she put away the umbrella and supported herself with both hands on either side, leaning down.

She tilted her head closer to those lips and gave a light peck.

She intended to leave after that light touch like a dragonfly on water, but Ning Fuyi's hand was still around her waist, so her attempt to get up failed. She was pulled back to her original position, her hair rising with the wind, slowly covering them both.

"What are you doing?" Chu Qingqiu said in a breathy voice.

"Haven't kissed enough," Ning Fuyi giggled. She suddenly straightened up to kiss Chu Qingqiu's forehead, making a soft "pop" sound.

"Yiyi!" Chu Qingqiu helplessly tried to cover her mouth, but the other party was relentless, holding her and insisting on kissing her eyes and nose all over before finally letting go and spinning to her feet.

Chu Qingqiu covered her face with one hand, glaring at her with a mixture of annoyance and laughter, while Ning Fuyi had already seemingly forgotten what she had done and picked up the wood axe to chop trees.

"Little demon."

Chu Qingqiu muttered this rebuke under her breath, but as soon as the words fell, Ning Fuyi's shout came from over there: "Divine Venerable, come help me chop wood!"

"Coming," Chu Qingqiu stood up.

Ning Fuyi didn't use any immortal power at all, relying solely on the speed of swinging the axe to quickly chop two large bundles of firewood, which she tied securely with rope and carried on her shoulder down the mountain.

Perhaps because of Su Mo's memories, Chu Qingqiu chopped even faster than her, and the clearing was soon piled high with dry wood, too much to carry away.

The sight of the noble Divine Venerable in white robes wielding a wood axe was endlessly memorable. Ning Fuyi stopped to steal glances for quite a while before grinning with complete satisfaction.

When they returned to the small town, Yuange was lying in the cradle taking a nap, while the woman sat on a wooden stump, supporting her head with her hand as she dozed. As soon as she saw Ning Fuyi's figure, she slapped her thigh and stood up, rushing toward her.

"Young lady finally returned! With such heavy dew in the deep night, what if you had fallen or stumbled? It's all that brat's fault, insisting on wanting sweet soup in the middle of the night!"

"It's fine, didn't I return safe and sound?" Ning Fuyi smiled as she mysteriously set down the two bundles of firewood and waved to beckon Chu Qingqiu.

Only then did Chu Qingqiu gracefully walk in from outside the door, easily setting down the two bundles of wood she had been carrying.

Her elegant bearing made the woman stare straight for a moment. When she came to her senses, she smiled awkwardly, not knowing what to do with her hands: "This young lady is..."

"She's my..." Ning Fuyi was stammering uncertainly about how to introduce her when Chu Qingqiu spoke up to resolve the situation for her, saying gently: "Friend."

"Friend, friend!" The woman put her hands behind her back to wipe them, constantly grinning sheepishly. "Of course, Young Lady Ning has extraordinary talents, so naturally those she associates with are no ordinary people either..."

"There's still some noodles with meat sauce¹ left in the room, I'll go..."

"No need to trouble yourself, I've already eaten on the road," Chu Qingqiu shook her head. "To come disturbing you at this hour is quite presumptuous of us."

"Oh my, what does this matter? It's just a matter of clearing out a room. As long as you two don't mind, everything can be arranged," the woman smiled as she went to wake Yuange. "Yuange, it's getting cold at night, come back to the room with mother to sleep."

Yuange opened her drowsy eyes, squinting at Chu Qingqiu, then her eyes widened round. No longer shy, she jumped down and called out: "Immortal sister!"

Chu Qingqiu was stunned at first, then bent down: "Why do you call me that?"

"Mother says those who are born beautiful are immortals..." Yuange bit her fingernail and said in her childish voice.

Seeing her like this, Chu Qingqiu actually showed a look of affection. She crouched down and extended her soft hand toward her: "Do you know how old I am? How can you call me sister?"

Upon hearing this, Yuange suddenly bounced and jumped into her arms, using her small, soft body to get close and examine her, then looked at Ning Fuyi.

Ning Fuyi winked at her.

"You're still sister," Yuange said with certainty.

The warm little body pressed close to her, and Chu Qingqiu found she didn't feel repulsed. She curved her lips in a light smile and patted Yuange's head: "Call me whatever you like, now go to sleep quickly."

Yuange obediently nodded, pattering over to the woman's side and offering her hand. The woman smiled and took her hand, leading her back to the room.

After the door closed, Chu Qingqiu stood up, and her previously empty hand was filled by another hand, pulling her back.

"What spell did you cast on her?" Ning Fuyi asked.

"Just a small trick to keep her body healthy," Chu Qingqiu replied. Her smile hadn't faded, like the gentle moonlight of spring.

"So you don't dislike children after all," Ning Fuyi said meaningfully.

"When did I ever say I disliked them?"

"When I was a child, you certainly didn't treat me this way. You couldn't wait to throw me off Purple Cloud Peak," Ning Fuyi lowered her eyes, pretending to sigh.

Chu Qingqiu was completely helpless: "Are you going to remember the time I threw you out for the rest of your life?"

"Childhood trauma can never be erased in a lifetime," Ning Fuyi bit her red lips and let go, turning around.

Chu Qingqiu reached out to pull her back: "Alright, I apologize to you."

When Ning Fuyi still didn't speak, she used both hands to grasp her wrists. Though not quite swaying her back and forth, she still made a coaxing gesture: "I was wrong, is that okay?"

The corners of Ning Fuyi's mouth had long since failed to suppress their upward curve. She pretended to compromise and turned around, nodding: "Then I'll forgive you, sister."

Chu Qingqiu was about to nod when she suddenly frowned: "What did you call me?"

"You let a little child call you sister, so what's wrong with me calling you that?" Ning Fuyi swept her hair braid aside with her hand and walked spiritedly into the house.

Chu Qingqiu stood there, her brow furrowed for a long while, but ultimately had no choice but to helplessly lift her legs and follow her inside.

The door closed, keeping the howling wind outside. Bean-sized lamplight was lit, its dim yellow glow illuminating the room as the woody and earthy scents characteristic of old houses entered their nostrils.

Though extremely simple, it was clean and tidy. The quilts gave off the scent of soap beans². Ning Fuyi lifted her robes and sat down, looking up to find that the woman had already heated water for washing.

"You probably don't need it, right?" Ning Fuyi pointed at the water basin. After Chu Qingqiu shook her head, she lay down. "I don't need it either."

But Chu Qingqiu didn't come near for a long while. She stood by the door the entire time, then said hesitantly: "The bed is quite narrow. I should find somewhere else."

"It's not the first time we've slept together," Ning Fuyi turned over, propping her head up with her fist and smiling.

Though that was true, but...

Chu Qingqiu hid her hands and walked with lowered head to the table.

The room had warmed up somewhat when Chu Qingqiu suddenly spoke: "Are your injuries better?"

"Mostly healed," Ning Fuyi replied. "These past few days I've rarely used immortal power. Though my legs and feet are a bit tired, it's good for healing."

"Let me see that book of yours," Chu Qingqiu suddenly extended her hand toward her.

Ning Fuyi was initially confused, then realized she was referring to the Divine-Demon Manual. She extracted the wrinkled booklet from her thought-pearl³ and used immortal power to float it over to her.

Chu Qingqiu took it and flipped through it under the candlelight.

"It is indeed an ancient text, recording things related to gods and demons," Chu Qingqiu nodded.

Hearing this, Ning Fuyi suddenly perked up considerably, straightening up like a carp and kneeling as she crawled to the foot of the bed: "You can actually understand it?"

Chu Qingqiu's fingers still held the book, her gaze looking at her over the spine: "I'm at least ten thousand years older than you. If I couldn't understand some ancient text, wouldn't I have lived all these years in vain?"

Ning Fuyi was so happy she almost clapped her hands. The worries of these past few days vanished like smoke, and she got down to sit across from Chu Qingqiu, her phoenix eyes blazing: "If I had known earlier, I would have shown it to you sooner. I've been struggling to read it for so long in vain."

"None of the people around me understand this script, and those who do understand it I dare not ask. Even Jiuying⁴ looks at it like it's a book from heaven," Ning Fuyi complained.

Chu Qingqiu was amused by her and wanted to laugh, but her expression remained serious: "Jiuying is a divine beast. Which divine beast have you ever seen that could read literature and history?"

"That makes sense," Ning Fuyi nodded, then pushed the book closer to her eyes. "Then please help me look at it."

"It says that when heaven and earth first opened, gods and demons were both nurtured by heaven and earth, but each had different pure and turbid qualities, which gave birth to these two completely different beings. But demonic energy easily damages people's minds, so the Six Realms revere true gods and reject demons."

Ning Fuyi listened in a daze, and Chu Qingqiu flipped back and forth some more, then shook her head: "What's described in here is really complex, and some parts are patched together from different sources. Though there are indeed some genuine things, the person who recorded it was too careless, making it a jumbled mess."

"I knew that old man was unreliable," Ning Fuyi slumped over the table.

Seeing her disappointed expression, Chu Qingqiu waved her hand to conjure brush, ink, paper, and inkstone: "It's fine, I'll copy down the text for you. When you read it again later, it should be much smoother."

She lowered her head to copy seriously, the brush tip touching paper with a rustling sound. Half her face was in the candlelight, the other half hidden in shadow. Ning Fuyi propped her chin on her hands watching her, and before long, she actually lost consciousness.

When she woke again, it was still pitch black outside the window, the strong wind still howling, with leaves occasionally striking the window frame and making thumping sounds.

Ning Fuyi rubbed the impression marks on her face and sat up, discovering that the woman across from her still sat with her upper body straight, her gaze calm, her hand never stopping.

Beside her left hand was already a small stack of papers, each one filled with writing, and some places even had drawings to explain things.

"How long have you been copying?" Ning Fuyi stood and came behind her, looking at her bamboo-like figure sitting upright, feeling a pang of heartache.

"Just two hours," Chu Qingqiu said. "Not long."

"Two hours?" Ning Fuyi suddenly reached over to snatch the brush from her hand and set it down. "Enough, this matter isn't urgent. We can continue tomorrow."

Chu Qingqiu's now-empty hand paused for a moment, then she turned around: "If you're tired, go to sleep first. Don't forget you still have injuries."

"You've also chased after me all this way. Won't you rest?" Ning Fuyi took her hand. Though Chu Qingqiu seemed unwilling, she still followed the force of her pull and stood up.

"You're suddenly being so good to me, I'm not quite used to it," Ning Fuyi smiled. She could clearly sense that Chu Qingqiu was deliberately accommodating and indulging her, not opposing anything she said.

"Am I making things difficult for you?" Chu Qingqiu's eyes flowed with emotion as she said softly.

"How could it be difficult? It's just that seeing you so careful and cautious makes me feel uncomfortable," Ning Fuyi pulled her to sit down and rested her head on her shoulder.

"You say you're afraid, but how could I not be afraid too?" Chu Qingqiu said softly.

"Afraid of me? Afraid I'll take my own life?"

Chu Qingqiu deliberated for a moment, then still nodded: "Actually, in my previous life when I was searching for you among the Red Spider Lilies⁵, I was already determined that in the next life I would treat you well, to prevent you from going astray. But living again, I still don't know how to treat you properly."

"I can only use every method to protect you completely, but I still didn't do well. Fortunately, after the curse was removed, you gained so many people who truly care for you. With them there, I can also feel at ease."

"But now..."

"Don't worry, I'm not that fragile," Ning Fuyi lifted her head. "Even ants cling to life⁶, and I'm certainly no ant. I will definitely live on."

Having sailed through thousands of trials, still unafraid of wind and clouds. Having crossed hundreds of rivers, still laughing at the mountains and rivers.

"Good to know," Chu Qingqiu raised her hand to pinch her earlobe, feeling it burning hot while becoming aware of how intimate this gesture was.

So she turned and lay down on the inner side, her back to Ning Fuyi.

"Divine Venerable, if you insist on not resting, are you worried about something?" Ning Fuyi lay down with her clothes on and blew out the candle.

"Perhaps," Chu Qingqiu closed her eyes and shook her head, her fingers curling around her clothing, her voice as low and slow as exhaled breath. "I'm worried about myself."

Unable to control her emotions.

Footnotes:

1. **臊子面 (saozi noodles)** - A traditional Chinese noodle dish with meat sauce, particularly popular in northern China.
2. **皂角 (soap beans)** - Natural soap made from the pods of the Chinese honey locust tree, commonly used for washing in traditional China.
3. **一念珠 (thought-pearl)** - A magical storage device mentioned earlier in the story.
4. **九婴 (Jiuying)** - A mythical nine-headed dragon-like creature from Chinese mythology.
5. **彼岸花 (Red Spider Lilies)** - Flowers that bloom in the underworld, associated with death and separation in Chinese and Japanese culture.
6. **蝼蚁尚且偷生** - A classical Chinese idiom meaning "even ants cling to life," expressing that all living beings have an instinct for survival.